

Togo



A narrow country wedged between Ghana and Benin and dominated by the large port of Lomé.

1884 Togo becomes a German protectorate. After Germany's defeat in World War I, it is divided between France and Britain.

1960 French sector becomes independent as Togo, while the British part is joined to Ghana.

1967 Gnassingbé Eyadéma takes power in a coup and is Africa's longest-serving ruler by the time of his death; he rules by repression and brutality.

2005 Eyadéma dies. He is replaced by his son Faure, who wins elections widely condemned as rigged.

2006 Government and opposition parties agree to a transitional government.

Benin



A former slave-trading state and French colony wedged between Togo and Nigeria.

1400s Kingdom of Benin established under the Obas.

1500s Portuguese seafarers commence trade with coastal rulers.

1620 The Fon, indigenous slave traders, found kingdom of Dahomey.

1850s After the abolition of the slave trade, palm oil becomes the main export.

1863 Porto Novo becomes a French protectorate.

1890–94 Armed conflict between Dahomey and France, ending with French victory.

1892 French establish protectorate.

1901 Present borders of Dahomey, as it was then known, fixed by France.

1904 Becomes part of French West Africa.

1960 Full independence from France.

1972 Military coup: Marxism–Leninism is official ideology. It is dropped in 1989.

1975 Renamed Benin.

1990 Benin introduces multi-party democracy. President Kerekou is beaten by Nicéphore Soglo in elections in 1991 and respects the result. Kerekou is re-elected in 1996 amid accusations of fraud.

«280–81 The Slave Trade

Nigeria



Africa's most populous state and once home to the ancient kingdom of Benin.

800 BCE Nok people develop first organized society in the region.

1000 CE Kanem becomes major state, which grows rich on trans-Saharan trade.

1400s Oyo and Benin states flourish in the south, the Ife in the west, while the Igbo live in small villages in the southeast. First Portuguese landings.

1500s Songhai Empire controls the north until conquered by Morocco in 1591.

1700s With Britain taking the lead, the slave trade develops to the point where 15,000 slaves are being exported annually from the Bight of Benin and a further 15,000 from the Bight of Biafra.

1861 The British annex Lagos and the process of formal colonization begins.

1886 Royal Niger Company given official responsibility for British sphere of influence along the Niger and Benue rivers. British armed forces coerce local rulers into accepting British rule.

1900 The Royal Niger Company's charter is revoked.

1900 British Protectorate of Northern Nigeria is established.

1906 Lagos is incorporated into the Protectorate of Southern Nigeria.

1909 West Africa Frontier Force (WAFF) is established; the subjugation of the north of the region begins.

1914 Protectorates of Northern and Southern Nigeria are joined to form the colony of Nigeria.

1960 Independence from Britain as a federated state.

1961 Northern part of UN Trust Territory of the Cameroons is incorporated as part of Nigeria's Northern Region.

1966 First military coup, led by Major General Ironsi. Thousands of Igbo in Northern Region are massacred.

1966–75 General Gowon in power.

1967–70 Civil war: Lieutenant Colonel Ojukwu calls for secession of oil-rich east under its new name, Biafra. Over one million Nigerians die before secessionists are defeated by federal forces.

1978 Political parties are legalized. Must represent national, not tribal, interests.

1979 Elections won by Alhaji Shehu Shagari and the National Party of Nigeria (NPN); return to civilian government.



Beauty in bronze

The kingdom of Benin flourished in southern Nigeria from the 1200s to the 1600s. Its craftworkers used the lost-wax process to cast beautiful portrait heads like this one in bronze.

1983 Military coup. Major General Mohammed Buhari heads the Supreme Military Council.

1985 Major General Ibrahim Babangida heads a bloodless coup, promising a return to democracy.

1993 Elections annulled; Babangida resigns; military sets up Interim National Government (ING). The army, headed by General Sani Abacha, takes over.

1995 Ban on parties is lifted. Military tribunal convicts former head of state General Olusegun Obasanjo and 39 others for plotting coup. Execution of novelist Ken Saro-Wiwa and eight other Ogoni activists: Commonwealth suspends Nigeria's membership.

1998 Abacha dies; his successor announces a timetable for restoring civilian rule by 1999.

1999 Elections for state governors, legislature, and presidency won by Olusegun Obasanjo. Commonwealth membership restored.

2000 Ethnic violence escalates, threatening national unity.

2001 Bauchi becomes the tenth state to introduce sharia law; divisions widen between the Muslim north and Christian south.

2006 Militants in Niger Delta attack oil pipelines. Nigeria cedes sovereignty over disputed Bakassi peninsula to Cameroon.

2007 Umaru Yar'Adua of the PDP wins presidential elections.

2008 200 people killed in Muslim–Christian rioting in central town of Jos.

2010 Further religious clashes kill 300. Vice President Goodluck Jonathan becomes president after Umar Yar'Adua dies following a long illness and prolonged absence in Saudi Arabia.

«280–81 The Slave Trade
«320–21 Completing the Map

Cameroon



Dubbed “Africa in miniature” on account of its 230 different peoples and varied habitats.

1100s Expansion of the Kanem-Bornu Empire to include the northern regions.

1472 Portuguese explorers arrive; later development of slave trade by Europeans.

1884 Germany declares Kamerun protectorate.

1922 Most of the territory is mandated to France, with the remainder to Britain.

1960 Gains independence from France; northern part joins Nigeria in 1961.

1984 Country is renamed Cameroon.

1992 First democratic elections for 30 years return ruling party to power.

2000 World Bank funding is approved for oil and pipeline project.

2008 Last part of disputed Bakassi Peninsula handed over by Nigeria.

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Equatorial Guinea



The only Spanish-speaking state in Africa, with the potential of great wealth from oil.

1778 Portugal hands over Fernando Po (Bioko) and Annobon islands to Spain. Spain later develops a trading post on islands off the coast of Rio Muni.

1858 Spain permanently occupies Bioko, developing cocoa plantations.

1900 Treaty of Paris confirms Spanish rule over Rio Muni. Forestry concessions and oil palm plantations are developed in Rio Muni, with small cocoa and coffee plantations later.

1959 Fernando Po and Rio Muni are incorporated into metropolitan Spain; the inhabitants gain full Spanish citizenship.

1968 Independence, with Francisco Macias Nguema, from Esangui Fang clan, as president. Macias abandons democracy, and installs a repressive regime.

1991 Multi-party constitution.